



Plants for cracks in walls and paving

Dull walls and paved patios in shady yards can be transformed into decorative features with leafy ferns or small flowering plants between the cracks.

While some plants such as small ferns may seed themselves in dry stone walls, creeping campanulas will grow in the most inhospitable of places, their stems of small blue flowers enlivening structures in deep shade. Shady paving offers a good home for a range of pretty saxifrages, and the golden-yellow flowers of fleabane are perfect for lightening paving or walls in gloomy gardens. For year-round color in shaded walls and patios, opt for evergreen bugleweed, the Hart's tongue fern, and creeping phlox.



PERENNIAL SMALL

Alchemilla alpina

ALPINE LADY'S MANTLE A mound-forming perennial with lobed, white-edged green leaves, silky-haired beneath, and greenish yellow summer-flower spikes. Grow in cracks in walls and paving with moisture. Cut back untidy foliage and blooms.

↑6in (15cm) ↔ 24in (60cm) or more

☾ Z3–7



PERENNIAL MEDIUM

Asplenium scolopendrium

HART'S TONGUE FERN This evergreen fern has an upright rosette of tongue-shaped, long, leathery bright green fronds that have spores across the undersides. Plant in shady cracks in walls and paving. Crispum Group (above) has crinkled-edged leaves.

↑28in (70cm) ↔ 24in (60cm)

☾ Z5–9



PERENNIAL SMALL

Athyrium niponicum var. *pictum*

JAPANESE PAINTED FERN This deciduous fern has deeply divided, purple- and silver-tinted gray-green leaves. Plant it in damp shaded paving or walls. Thrives in deep shade.

↑12in (30cm) ↔ indefinite

☾ Z4–8



PERENNIAL SMALL

Ajuga reptans 'Atropurpurea'

BUGLEWEED This mat-forming evergreen perennial has creeping stems of bronze-purple leaves and short spikes of small deep blue blooms from late spring to early summer. Plant in a shady paving or cracks in a wall. Considered invasive in some areas.

↑6in (15cm) ↔ 3ft (1m)

☾ Z3–9



PERENNIAL SMALL

Campanula poscharskyana

SERBIAN BELLFLOWER This spreading perennial forms low mounds of round, serrated-edged midgreen leaves. Starry violet flowers appear on leafy stems from summer to early fall. Use it to cascade from walls or spread between paving.

↑6in (15cm) ↔ indefinite

☾ Z3–8



PERENNIAL SMALL

Corydalis lutea

YELLOW CORYDALIS This evergreen perennial forms a mound of delicate, ferny gray-green leaves. Slender yellow flowers with spurred petals appear from late spring to summer. Sprinkle the seeds in paving and on top of stone walls.

↑↔ 12in (30cm)

☾ Z5–7



PERENNIAL SMALL

Erigeron aureus

FLEABANE A clump-forming perennial with small, spoon-shaped, hairy gray-green leaves and large, golden-yellow daisy-like blooms in summer. Plant it in cracks in walls and paving; tolerates light shade only. 'Canary Bird' (above) has pale blooms.

↑4in (10cm) ↔ 6in (15cm)

☾ Z5–8 (N)



PERENNIAL SMALL

Geranium asphodeloides

CRANESBILL A spreading deciduous perennial with small, deeply cut round leaves and masses of starry, magenta-veined white or light pink flowers in early summer. Grow it between paving stones or in cracks in walls in part shade.

↑↔ 12in (30cm)

☾ Z6–9